released every day after the elephant had its play.[6]

Eventually, Mirak's sayyid ancestry saved him; he was pardoned – though his disappearance from the records indicates a subdued, even smothered, future career.

On the other hand, when the Mirzas began to try their luck on the heels of the Uzbeks' defeat ('the army was not yet rested from its labours'),[7] Akbar ignored them. It would be 'contrary to the canons of reason', writes Abul Fazl, for Akbar to deal personally with such men. It may be that Akbar realized he couldn't spend all his time racing about his realm, swatting at insurgent warlords. He needed, also, to strengthen his own position. The Hindustan he ruled had not grown an inch in the three years since the Uzbek troubles began:[8] scattered holdings in Rajasthan, some cities in Malwa, the eastern provinces he had just wrested back from the Uzbeks, and Agra, Delhi and Lahore. Akbar still needed to build the empire he would one day rule; and he needed, also, more land, more revenue, for the armies that would help him build it and the officers who would help him run it.

In short, he needed conquest.

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It began with a joke. Or that, at any rate, is how Abul Fazl tells it. Akbar returned from Jaunpur to Agra and set off, almost immediately, on a hunt to Bari, a favourite hunting ground for cheetah and deer nearby.[9] Afterwards, Akbar continued to march, now heading east to Dholpur, then south to Gwalior. No one was sure where the padishah was going; certainly not Sakat Singh, a Rajput prince from the kingdom of Mewar who was travelling with him.

One day, it seems, Akbar remarked to Sakat Singh that while so many chiefs of Hindustan had acknowledged Akbar's suzerainty, the Rajput's father, the rana of Mewar, was yet to do so. The padishah 'proposed to march against him and punish him' and asked 'what service [Sakat Singh] would render in this case'.

It was not the most amusing of pleasantries, but it stuck in Sakat Singh's mind. Some days later, the Rajput prince ran away. 'He did not know that it was all a joke,' says Abul Fazl. Why would Akbar, after all, 'proceed